

facturing hub rests on building core physical infrastructure, providing best-in-class policy instruments, developing a pool of skilled manpower and providing the most conducive business environment.

We plan to develop a mega electronics hub in Visakhapatnam, a hardware park in Kakinada and 20 EMCs across the state, including in the greenfield capital city of Amaravati. Four districts, namely, Nellore, Chittoor, Visakhapatnam and Krishna, have been designated brownfield EMCs.

Q. What are the steps taken by your government to ensure ease of doing business in the ESDM sector?

A. I am pleased to inform you that within 15 months of the bifurcation of the state, Andhra Pradesh has made an impact through its investor-friendly initiatives. It has been ranked second among states in the country with regards to ease of doing business as per World Bank's report for Department of Industrial Promotion & Policy.

We have a single-desk portal that provides all clearances and approvals within 21 working days to set up an industry in the state. Apart from this, we have introduced labour reforms, permitted self-certifications under relevant laws and online systems for registration and filing of returns of state taxes. We have also declared the electronics hardware industry as an essential service under Andhra Pradesh Essential Services Maintenance Act.

Our vision and continuous push is to transform the state into the best investment destination, not just in India but to compete with the best countries.

Q. What is the current investment status in the ESDM sector of the state, and what is the projection for this financial year?

A. My government believes in being proactive and following a targeted approach for attracting investments. Over the past 15 months, we have gained significant traction in the mobile manufacturing sector.

Foxconn has started manufacturing mobile phones from Sri City. Recently, Xiaomi's first made-in-India smartphone was launched; it was manufactured in Andhra Pradesh. Three of India's leading handset companies, namely, Micromax, Celkon and Karbonn, are also setting up manufacturing units in Tirupati.

I want to create a mobile manufacturing hub in Andhra Pradesh. Already, with the interest shown by mobile manufacturing companies, I am hopeful that six to seven million phones will be manufactured in the state by next year (2016), and around 30,000 to 40,000 new jobs will be created in the sector.

Q. What is the status of the different thrust areas mentioned in Andhra Pradesh State ESDM Policy 2014-2020 such as establishing 20 EMCs, a centre for excellence on fabless semiconductors and the like?

A. We have identified six locations, namely, Visakhapatnam, Vijayawada, Kakinada, Sri City, Tirupati and Anantapur, that are available for investors to start manufacturing units immediately. We will continue to identify and add EMCs in the state. Discussions are on with semiconductor companies to set up fabless semiconductor facilities, and there are plans to create a silicon campus, too.

Q. How does your government plan to ensure policy implementation for promoting electronics and IT in the state?

A. As I mentioned earlier, Andhra Pradesh has set up an agency (Andhra Pradesh Electronics & IT Agency) exclusively to address the needs of the electronics and IT industries. This is headed by professionals from the industry, who will help in understanding the needs of the companies and, hence, enable us to make the process of setting up and doing business in Andhra Pradesh easy. The agency is tasked with the responsibility of creating the ecosys-

tem needed for electronics manufacturing within identified clusters.

Q. How will the state foster entrepreneurship and an innovation culture in the ESDM sector?

A. Andhra Pradesh has laid heavy emphasis on promoting innovation and developing an entrepreneurial and start-up culture in the state. We have released an innovation and start-up policy with a target to have an entrepreneur in every family in the state. We want to incubate 5000 companies and start-ups, and have also proposed to mobilise a venture capital fund to drive innovation.

Andhra Pradesh is the first state in India to have a dedicated innovation society to foster innovation and entrepreneurship. The society has adopted a two-pronged approach:

1. Facilitate the setting up of innovation hubs in multiple locations where incubators help entrepreneurs to pursue their ambitions. We have provided state-of-art environment and infrastructure for the benefit of such entrepreneurs.
2. Facilitate the setting up of incubation centres at universities and institutes of higher education, with an aim to establish 100 innovation hubs across the state by 2020.

Q. What are the initiatives taken by Andhra Pradesh government to promote e-governance?

A. I have always been a keen proponent of using IT in governance. My focus is to make Andhra Pradesh the top state in terms of the quality and number of e-services in India.

We have Mee Seva project, which has been recommended by Department of Administrative Reforms and Public Grievances (DARPG) for country-wide replication. Currently, 311 services are being offered through Mee Seva. Another 150 services are being identified. With more than 4000 kiosks and a dedicated network to support the service, Mee Seva is one of the most robust citizen